

ADDRESS AND ADMONITION BY ASIWAJU ADEGBOYEGA S. AWOMOLO, SAN, AT THE PRE-SWEARING-IN INDUCTION PROGRAMME FOR NEW SENIOR ADVOCATES OF NIGERIA – TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 23, 2025

THEME: THE SILK RANK: PRESERVING THE LEGACY OF DISTINCTION

Prince Lateef O. Fagbemi SAN, the Chairman, Body of Senior Advocates of Nigeria; the Honourable Attorney General and Minister of Justice; My Lords; fellow Senior Advocates of Nigeria, Senior Advocates of Nigeria designates. Let me, at the beginning of my speech; thank the Chairman, Prince Lateef O. Fagbemi SAN, for authorizing the Organizing Committee under the leadership of Chief Paul Usoro SAN to invite and list me for this contribution.

In his letter to me dated the 18th of September, 2025, he graciously allowed me 5 to 10 minutes to make my remarks in the nature of words of advice. I have had the privilege of listening to very eminent, distinguished, and learned leaders of the Judiciary and the Bar, each of them admonishing you on the occasion of your pre-conferment as Senior Advocates of Nigeria and your obligation in sustaining the legacy of distinction as a Senior Advocate of Nigeria.

I am aware that the processes each of you went through to be here today were rigorous, tasking, and sometimes, along the way, frustrating. But because you were determined to let opportunity meet your preparation; success has come your way today. I know that whatever God has ordained, no one can change it.

It is true that the race is not to the swift, neither is the battle to the strongest or fittest, bread to the wise, nor riches to men of understanding, nor favour to men of skill but time and chance happens to them all (Ecclesiastes 9:11). Permit my modesty to say that in July 1992, I was honored to wear the rank of Senior Advocate of Nigeria. I was the youngest of the 7 (seven), while Alhaji Femi Okunnu, S.A.N., CON, was the

most senior. In that year, the total number of SAN from inception was 88 (eighty-eight). Today, we have about 900 (nine hundred) Senior Advocates of Nigeria (SAN) and by Monday, the 29th of September 2025 we will be about 959 (Nine hundred and fifty nine) Senior Advocates of Nigeria (SAN).

I am sure you know that whether in democracy or military dictatorship, the Judiciary and, in fact, the Bar has always been at the center of all discussions concerning good governance, rule of law, political stability, and human rights and their abuses. Since 1999, every conversation around these concerns started with the role of Senior Advocates of Nigeria as playing major and determinant role. In recent times, Senior Advocates of Nigeria are at the heart of national conversations. The Chairmen of ICPC, EFCC, and critics of the social malady known as “corruption” often pointed at the Senior Advocates of Nigeria. Whether the allegations of the misdemeanors are local or global, Senior Advocates are sighted.

I cannot advise or tell you what the law is, or what roles are carved out for you as Senior Advocates. You know the law more than I do. But the Yorubas say: *"Ti omode ba l'aso bi agba, ko le l'akisa to; sugbon ojo owo kan mbo fun akisa."* (A child may have as many clothes as his elders, but he cannot have as many rags, someday, there will be a need for those rags.)

I wish each and every one of you to know the **3 Hs** that I believe will be useful to you as we approach the **D-Day** — next Monday, the 29th of September, 2025 when you will sign and swear, as you are formally conferred with and decorated with the rank as a Senior Advocate of Nigeria.

It is the day of little beginning, and you must do your best not to disgrace, disparage, or despise that day. Therefore, it is important that you do not remove, displace, ignore, or neglect the ancient landmarks, which your fathers and elders in the Body of Senior Advocates of Nigeria have set since 1975 when Chief F.R.A. Williams QC, SAN, CON, and Dr. Graham Douglas SAN were decorated at the Supreme Court, Lagos. You must be

very **honest** to and with yourself. You must be true to yourself, the noble and honorable profession of law, and the rank you wear. You must be guided at all times by the rules and ethics. Honesty will show the integrity of a man without speaking words. Honesty will lead you to know that the height your leaders in the rank attained was not reached by sudden flight. Precept upon precept, line upon line, like building brick by brick, you will get to where you desire.

Honesty, which is regarded as the best policy, will not allow you to be greedy for money, gold, or any material wealth. The law of nature is such that you can never have enough. However, honesty will keep your mind in the law of God. In all knowing, covert and know peace and trusting God that tomorrow is better

I can say from experience upon your elevation as a Senior Advocate, you can no longer be poor. You can never again beg for bread, you can never for any reason go borrowing. You can never go back to where you were coming from. You are now a great lawyer.

The second **H** is **Humility**. It is true that power, position, and things associated with them are tempting or sometimes intoxicating like wine. Therefore, humility must never leave you, because arrogance or pride destroys. Your humility must be seen by everyone who comes across you henceforth. It is the light of God that shines brighter and brighter. Wealth will soon come, fame is here, goodwill will follow, and global recognition will come within a short while — and when God sees your humility, He will give you **honour** that no man gives.

Honour is one of the greatest attributes that follow a man who is honest and humble. Good name is better than gold and silver. A man honoured has his name ring bells, open doors, create a magical image of one to be trusted, and brings goodness. A man honored stands before Presidents, nobles and kings. When you are honored as a Senior Advocate of Nigeria, whether at the Bar or Bench, you will be respected, you will be treated with great dignity. These attributes will make you empathetic towards your

colleagues, whether of the Inner Bar or Outer Bar. Honour no doubt reflects faithfulness, trustworthiness, sincerity and dependability as a professional.

Permit me to say that here in Abuja, there are not less than 150 Senior Advocates of Nigeria. Everyone within the ambit of this region knows the families of each other. We empathize with each other, celebrate with each other, and over the years built relationships that have endured for over 20 years. Senior Advocates residing in Abuja are happy. There is one BOSAN with one constitution, and I believe the legacy of love, empathy, and sharing is such that must be sustained at all levels and areas where Senior Advocates are resident.

In conclusion, permit me to thank the Honourable Attorney-General and Minister of Justice, Prince Lateef Olasunkanmi Fagbemi, SAN, My Lords that have shared their thoughts and wisdom. I thank the Leadership committee for this programme which has become an annual event before the conferment of the rank of Senior Advocate of Nigeria.

I am grateful for the honour of being part of this programme.

Asiwaju Adegboyega S. Awomolo, SAN

Member, BOTC, BOSAN

Life Bencher

23rd September, 2025